The Elixir That Transmutes into Gold

Dhātupāda · Toh 2394 · Derge Tengyur

གསེར་འགྱུར་གྱི་རྩི་ཞེས་བྱ།

The Elixir That Transmutes into Gold, whose Sanskrit title appears in the source as Dhāturpāda and whose Tibetan title is Gser 'gyur gyi rtsi, is a short alchemical instruction in verse that opens with homage to the goddess Vajravārāhī. Framed as a means of perfecting the transcendent perfection of generosity and gathering the accumulations of merit, it gives practical recipes for transmuting metals. Combinations of ingredients such as pomegranate, medicinal salt, alum, green vitriol, sour beer, mercury, and pigments are said to turn iron into copper and copper into silver, culminating in the production of gold. The work is Toh 2394 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the treatises of the tantra section associated with the practical and esoteric instructions of the Indian adept traditions.

In the language of India: dhāturpāda nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Elixir That Transmutes into Gold.

I bow to the Mother Vajravārāhī.

To perfect the transcendent perfection of generosity,
the instructions on the elixir that transmutes into gold
I shall explain for the person who puts them into practice,
so that the accumulations may be gathered.

Nepalese pomegranate and medicinal salt,
mixed with alum and green vitriol,
should be combined with sour beer.
Leave this in a copper vessel for three days.
Then, after three weeks, twenty-one days,
through the medicinal elixir of the oral instructions,
thin sheets of iron turn into copper.

Mercury and mineral,
the sentsi pigment and cow dung
are made into an enclosure, and in its center
red copper is placed; it then turns into silver.

Horse hoof and sheep horn,
tortoise with its shell removed, together with śilā:

silver is added to molten gold,
and with eight parts of these combined
it is added to molten lead,
and in five months it turns into silver.

Make silver and bronze equal in amount,
and mix them in the measure of the lead.
Inside an open vessel,
by melting, all of it turns into silver.

Eight measures of human flesh,
and tin equal to that,
two measures of natron, and medicinal salt,
one measure of poison, and mercury in equal amount:
with the juice of the Himalayan herb
knead the preceding ingredients.
Put all of them inside a white horn,
or else in an earthenware vessel;
seal it mouth to mouth and roast it.
Leave it until the ingredients are ash, then take it out:
the silver will be accomplished, like the moon.

Take the dung of a newborn fawn,
melt it in the sun and apply it.
That, with a fourfold measure of powder,
is added to molten tin,
and when the liquid dries, it turns into silver.

Medicinal salt and borax,
yavakṣāra and sarjikā,
the juice of the white rtsi herb,
poison, and the water of hanumaśati
are combined with buffalo curd.
Leave this inside the lead for three days,
and roast it by a method that lets no smoke arise.
Silver transmutation dispels the suffering of poverty.

Having explained the procedure for transmuting into silver,
I shall explain the nectar that transmutes into gold.
In the snowy mountains

a supreme herb called rodantī is renowned.
Its leaves keep the ground never free of dew,
and a gold-colored juice drips from it.
Tin combined with mercury,
through the oral instructions on the ash procedure,
turns silver and copper into gold by mere touch.

First, by means of fire, perform
the procedure that keeps the mercury from escaping.
Then, knowing the essence of the medicines,
the yogin will accomplish transmutation into gold.
If one does not dwell together with others,
transmutation into gold will not be accomplished.
Therefore, by the wheel of union,
by whatever means, bind the mercury.
Once it is bound, anything at all turns into gold,
and by eating it, everything becomes a vajra body.

The instructions on the elixir that transmutes into gold, composed by the master Nāli, are complete.

Translator's Notes

• Many substance names in this alchemical text are uncertain. "Medicinal salt" renders sman tshe / sman tsha; "alum" and "green vitriol" interpret sa'u ra and ka ka si sa (likely saurāṣṭrī and kāsīsa); "sentsi pigment" (sen rtsi), "śilā," "the white rtsi herb" and "hanumaśati" are left close to the Tibetan because they could not be securely identified. "Fawn" reads she'u as sha'u. "Open vessel" for phyi lta'i snod is a guess. The line "If one does not dwell together with others" is literal; it may refer to a consort, given the following "wheel of union," which could also mean a vessel sealed mouth to mouth. The author's name (na li) is given as Nāli, but its Sanskrit form is uncertain.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.